

NPI Licensing Beyond Downward Entailment

Conference abstract

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Abstract

This abstract argues that negative polarity item (NPI) licensing cannot be reduced to downward entailment alone. Using Czech data with *většina* ‘most’, we show that NPIs can be acceptable in a genuinely non-monotonic environment, which is difficult to reconcile with classical Ladusaw-style accounts. The result supports a scope-based analysis on which NPIs mark narrow scope relative to their licensor rather than a specific monotonicity profile.

Abstract

Negative polarity items have traditionally been analyzed as requiring downward-entailing licensing environments. The present study re-examines that assumption with Czech data centered on the proportional quantifier *většina* ‘most’. Since *most* is genuinely non-monotonic, it provides a sharper test than standard downward-entailing versus upward-entailing contrasts.

We combined an acceptability task with an inference task. Speakers found NPIs more acceptable with *all* than with *some*, but importantly, *most* patterned in between rather than collapsing with *some*. In the inference task, *most* did not show a stable monotonicity profile, yet it still licensed the NPI in a way that was distinct from both classical downward-entailing and upward-entailing environments. This dissociation suggests that licensing is not exhausted by logical monotonicity.

The analysis is naturally captured by a scope-marking approach. In this view, the NPI signals narrow scope relative to its licensor, which allows licensing in environments that are not downward-entailing. A conference version of the paper can present the Czech examples in the standard linguex format.

The main contribution is empirical: the data identify a genuinely non-monotonic licensor that still interacts with NPIs. The theoretical payoff is that the licensing condition looks closer to scope than to downward entailment. More broadly, the findings support a grammar in which polarity sensitivity is domain-sensitive and mediated by structural scope relations rather than a single monotonicity check.

References

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